The Purpose of the Good, and How Sacrifice Reveals It

A topical study on Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, and the Obedience of Faith. All Scripture quotations are from the NET Bible.

Abstract

Scripture never treats goodness as a standard God happens to meet. Goodness is what God is, which means the question of what *the Good* is *for* is a question about God's own purpose (i.e. union with the people He made).

That purpose runs into a problem. Devotion is invisible. A person cannot see his own faith, and neither can anyone else, until something forces it into the open. Sacrifice is what forces it. It attaches a price to a conviction and then asks whether the person will pay.

This study traces that mechanism through Scripture. It begins with Abraham on Moriah, where God asks not for feeling but for a son. It then examines the counterfeit that Scripture worries about far more than open unbelief: the offering that is real but incomplete; e.g. Saul's kept livestock, Malachi's blemished lambs, the tower left half-built. Four terms come into focus along the way, and they are not synonyms. **Religion supplies the form, worship the disposition, sacrifice the cost, and the obedience of faith the settled pattern that results.** Scripture treats none of the first three as evidence on its own.

The pattern is finally shown to rest on Christ, who carried it through without reserve, so that what is asked of the believer is response rather than achievement.

1. Framing the Question

The question ***"what is the purpose of the Good?"*** is really a question about God. In Scripture, God is not merely good among other things. Good is what He is. Jesus makes this identification directly when a man calls him "good teacher":

> *"Good teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?" Jesus said to him, "Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone."* (**Mark 10:17–18**)

Jesus is not denying his own goodness. He is pointing the man to the source. Goodness is not a free-floating quality people can possess on their own. It is an attribute of God, and anything called good is good because it participates in Him.

This means the purpose of the Good is not an abstract ethical puzzle. It is the purpose of God being known, loved, and reflected in a creature who is not naturally like Him. The Good has a purpose because God has a purpose; i.e. to be united with the people He made, and to remake them in His likeness (**Genesis 1:26–2**7; **Romans 8:29**).

Sacrifice is the mechanism Scripture uses, from Genesis to Revelation, to move a person from admiring the Good in the abstract to being conformed to it. This is why sacrifice and worship sit so close together in the biblical vocabulary, and why obedience rather than sentiment is the proof that worship has happened.

2. Sacrifice as the Thing That Makes the Good Concrete

Abstract goodness costs a person nothing. A sacrifice is goodness with a price attached, and the price is what makes it real. The pattern is set at the very start of Abraham's story:

> *God said, "Take your son - your only son, whom you love, Isaac - and go to the land of Moriah! Offer him up there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains which I will indicate to you."* (**Genesis 22:2**)

God does not ask Abraham to feel devoted. He asks him to hand over the one thing Abraham cannot part with and still keep his own plans intact. The text spells out exactly what is being asked. Not a possession, not a habit, but *"your son... your only son... whom you love."* The sacrifice means something only because it costs Abraham the thing he loves most.

The writer of Hebrews reads this event as the interpretive key to what faith is:

> *By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac. He had received the promises, yet he was ready to offer up his only son... and he reasoned that God could even raise him from the dead, and in a sense he received him back from there.* (**Hebrews 11:17, 19**)

Abraham's faith was not a private conviction that stayed inside his head. It became visible (i.e. became actual) only in the moment he raised the knife. That is the whole argument of **Hebrews 11**. Faith is commended not because people believed correctly, but because their belief cost them something and they paid it. Abel's offering (**Hebrews 11:4**), Noah's ark (**11:7**), Moses' choice to be "ill-treated with the people of God" rather than "enjoy sin's fleeting pleasure" (**11:25**); every example is a person converting invisible conviction into a visible, costly act. That conversion is what sacrifice is.

This is why sacrifice illuminates the Good instead of merely referring to it. The Good, as an idea, is easy to affirm. The Good, as a sacrifice, forces a decision: will you give this up? The answer to that question, not the sincerity of the sentiment beforehand, is what Scripture treats as real.

3. The Structure of Sacrifice

3.1 Separation: giving requires losing

Willingness to be separated from a particular good is simply what a burnt offering *is*. The Hebrew term is *olah*; i.e. that which "goes up" entirely consumed, with nothing kept back. **Leviticus** prescribes an unblemished animal precisely because the value of the gift is what makes it a gift. Paul transfers this logic onto the whole person:

> *Therefore I exhort you, brothers and sisters, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a sacrifice - alive, holy, and pleasing to God - which is your reasonable service.* (**Romans 12:1**)

The NET Bible's own study note on this verse makes a dry but pointed observation: the trouble with living sacrifices is that they keep crawling off the altar. A dead sacrifice cannot renegotiate. A living one can and constantly wants to. The good a person is asked to separate from does not stay separated on its own. It must be laid back down.

3.2 The partial offering

Scripture is blunt that sacrifices are frequently partial (i.e. offered, but not offered whole) and it treats that partiality as an insult rather than as an approximation of obedience:

> *"There will be harsh condemnation for the hypocrite who has a valuable male animal in his flock but vows and sacrifices something inferior to the Lord. For I am a great king," says the Lord who rules over all.* (**Malachi 1:14**)

> *You are offering improper sacrifices on my altar, yet you ask, "How have we offended you?" By treating the table of the Lord as if it is of no importance!... you offer blind animals as a sacrifice, is that not wrong? And when you offer the lame and sick, is that not wrong as well?* (**Malachi 1:7–8**)

Notice what Malachi's audience is doing. They are still sacrificing. They have not stopped. They have simply kept back the best part and offered the leftover. This is not outright refusal but negotiated, partial compliance that still gets called worship.

Saul does the same thing on a larger scale, keeping the best of the plunder and calling it a sacrifice (**1 Samuel 15:15, 21**). Samuel's answer is the most direct statement in the Old Testament of the whole problem:

> *Does the Lord take pleasure in burnt offerings and sacrifices as much as he does in obedience? Certainly, obedience is better than sacrifice; paying attention is better than the fat of rams. For rebellion is like the sin of divination, and presumption is like the evil of idolatry.* (**1 Samuel 15:22–23**)

Saul's sacrifice is not fake. The animals are real, the altar is real, the ritual is real. What is fake is its completeness. He performed sacrifice as a substitute for the specific obedience God asked for; religious activity used to disguise an unfinished surrender.

3.3 The demand for total commitment

Jesus states the requirement without any softening:

> *"If anyone comes to me and does not hate his own father and mother, and wife and children, and brothers and sisters, and even his own life, he cannot be my disciple. Whoever does not carry his own cross and follow me cannot be my disciple."* (**Luke 14:26–27**)

> *"In the same way therefore not one of you can be my disciple if he does not renounce all his own possessions."* (**Luke 14:33**)

He frames this with the tower-builder and the king weighing battle odds (**Luke 14:28–32**). Half-committed discipleship is not a smaller version of the real thing. It is a failure to finish what was started, and that is worse than never starting, because the half-built tower stands as public evidence of insincerity. Total commitment is not one available level of devotion among several. It is the only kind Jesus recognizes as discipleship at all.

3.4 Why holding back feels inevitable

Paul names the reason this is hard, and he locates it correctly, not as a single bad choice but as an ongoing internal war:

> *Do you not know that if you present yourselves as obedient slaves, you are slaves of the one you obey, either of sin resulting in death, or obedience resulting in righteousness?* (**Romans 6:16**)

Every person is already a slave to something. Holding back a sacrifice is therefore not neutral. It is choosing to keep serving the other master a little longer. That is why the temptation feels so persistent. It is not resistance to one demand. It is the ongoing pull of an entire competing allegiance (compare **Matthew 6:24**).

3.5 The seam where faith stalls

The claim that some particular good simply cannot be surrendered connects directly to Romans 1:5, where Paul describes the entire purpose of his apostleship:

> *Through him we have received grace and our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles on behalf of his name.* (**Romans 1:5**)

The phrase "obedience of faith" (*hypakoē pisteōs*) is deliberately compact. Early interpreters and later Restoration-era writers alike have read it two ways that turn out not to be in conflict. It can mean the obedience that *consists of* faith, since believing is itself an act of submission to God's terms rather than one's own. It can also mean the obedience that faith *produces*, since real faith cannot stay inert. Either reading rules out the idea that a person can hold something back from God and still call his faith genuine.

The influences that press on a believer (i.e. demonic, spiritual, cultural, psychological) do their work exactly at this seam. They persuade a person that faith is compatible with keeping one particular good in reserve. Scripture's answer is consistent…, this is a category error. Faith that does not reach obedience has not yet arrived.

3.6 Mediocrity as a stable state

James gives the diagnosis for this kind of empty religiosity:

> *If someone thinks he is religious yet does not bridle his tongue, and so deceives his heart, his religion is futile. Pure and undefiled religion before God the Father is this: to care for orphans and widows in their misfortune and to keep oneself unstained by the world.* (**James 1:26–27**)

James's word for religion, *threskeia*, refers to the outward system of observance; the rituals, the identity markers, the things a person does in order to count as religious. His point is that this outward system can run alongside an unsurrendered inner life indefinitely. The result is a person who is sincerely religious and simultaneously withholding.

Mediocrity, on this reading, is not laziness. It is the stable, sustainable state of partial sacrifice: Saul's kept livestock, Malachi's blemished lambs, the seed choked by *"the worries of this life, the deceitfulness of wealth"* (**Matthew 13:22**). It looks like devotion because activity is present. What is missing is completion.

3.7 Temperance: the same structure in miniature

Temperance scales the whole argument down to a single daily choice. Paul reaches for an athletic metaphor to describe it:

> *Everyone who competes in the games exercises self-control in everything. They do it to receive a perishable wreath, but we an imperishable one.* (**1 Corinthians 9:25**)

Temperance requires giving up a real and immediate good (e.g. the pleasure of excess) for the sake of a good that is not yet present, whether discipline, health, virtue, or communion with God. This is sacrifice in miniature, the same structural choice Abraham faced, scaled to an ordinary decision.

If the structure of sacrifice really is foundational to human moral life, then temperance is not a separate virtue standing alongside sacrifice. It is sacrifice practiced at the smallest possible scale, which is exactly why it is one of the hardest disciplines to sustain.

The lesser good must be surrendered constantly, in small transactions, with no dramatic moment like Moriah to mark the decision. In one sense this is harder than Abraham's test rather than easier. There is no altar and no fixed point of completion, only the same choice repeated.

4. Religion, Worship, Sacrifice, and the Obedience of Faith

Scripture uses these four terms with real precision, even though English translations often blur them together. They are best understood as four layers of one act, moving from outward frame to inward reality.

Religion (*threskeia*) is the outward system: the observances, the community, the identifiable practice. **James 1:26–27** uses this word specifically and then defines "pure" religion not by its rituals but by what it produces, care for the vulnerable and an unstained life. Religion is the shape worship takes in a community. By itself it is not proof that anything real has happened inside the worshiper.

Worship is the posture of the heart directed toward God, the recognition of who He is and the submission that follows. Jesus moves worship away from geography and ritual correctness and onto sincerity of spirit:

> *"But a time is coming, and now is here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father seeks such people to be his worshipers. God is spirit, and the people who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."* (**John 4:23–24**)

This is a decisive move. Worship is not primarily a place or a form, whether Jerusalem or Gerizim, but a disposition. Yet a disposition by itself is invisible and unverifiable, including to the worshiper. This is exactly why worship needs sacrifice.

Sacrifice (*thusia*) is worship's currency, the concrete cost by which an invisible disposition becomes an actual event. Augustine's *City of God* states the relationship as precisely as any writer ever has:

> *"A true sacrifice is every work which is done that we may be united to God in holy fellowship, and which has a reference to that supreme good and end in which alone we can be truly blessed."* (*City of God*, Book X, Chapter 6)

Augustine draws this definition out of **Romans 12:1** and **Hosea 6:6**, and he uses it to explain why the Old Testament's outward sacrifices were never the point in themselves. They were symbols pointing to the inward, whole-life sacrifice they were meant to produce. Mercy shown to another person, in his words, *"if it is not shown for God's sake, is not a sacrifice."* The same external act can be a sacrifice or can be nothing at all, depending entirely on whether it is offered to God. This is the same logic Samuel applies to Saul and Malachi applies to the priests. Ritual form does not guarantee substance.

The obedience of faith (*hypakoē pisteōs*, Romans 1:5) is the completed result: the point at which worship has been proven real because it has been enacted as sacrifice, consistently, to the point of costing something. This is why Paul can say that the entire purpose of the gospel going out to the nations is to *"bring about the obedience of faith"* (**Romans 1:5**). Not merely correct belief, and not merely religious observance, but a life that has reorganized itself around what it claims.

Put the four together and the sequence is clear. Religion supplies the form. Worship supplies the disposition. Sacrifice supplies the proof; i.e. the moment the disposition costs something and the person pays it. The obedience of faith is the name for the whole thing once it has become a settled pattern rather than an isolated act.

Each of the first three can exist without the others. A person can have religion without worship, which is empty ritual (**Isaiah 29:13**). He can have worship without sacrifice, which is sincere feeling that never costs anything (**Ezekiel 33:31–32**). He can even have sacrifice without full obedience, which is Saul's partial compliance dressed up as devotion (**1 Samuel 15**). Only when form, disposition, cost, and settled pattern align does Scripture call it what Paul calls it.

5. Why Christ's Sacrifice Is the Template, Not Just the Payment

It would be easy to read all of this as a description of what is required of us and to miss that the pattern is first fulfilled in Christ, which is what makes it possible for anyone else. The writer of Hebrews quotes **Psalm 40** and puts these words in Christ's mouth at his incarnation:

> *"Sacrifice and offering you did not desire, but a body you prepared for me... Then I said, 'Here I am: I have come — it is written of me in the scroll of the book — to do your will, O God.'" ... By his will we have been made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.* (**Hebrews 10:5, 7, 10**)

Christ's whole life is described here as one continuous act of the same total sacrifice Abraham modeled and Saul failed to give, except carried all the way through, with nothing kept back, ending at the cross. This is why Paul can ground the living sacrifice of **Romans 12:1** in *"the mercies of God"* rather than in human effort. The pattern of total surrender was completed on our behalf first. What is asked of the believer is a response to that completed sacrifice, not an independent achievement.

6. Restoration Theology's Reading of "Obedience of Faith"

The Restoration Movement writers of the nineteenth century, reading Scripture with a deliberate return to the practice of the apostolic church rather than to later creeds, put particular weight on **Romans 1:5** for exactly this reason. Their consistent emphasis was that the New Testament never presents faith and obedience as two separate stages, one internal and one optional.

Faith that does not terminate in an actual, external, obeyed act (e.g. repentance confessed, baptism submitted to, a life reordered) was treated in this tradition as not yet the faith the New Testament describes. The logic matches James directly:

> *"faith, if it does not have works, is dead being by itself"* (**James 2:17**).

This reading does not add a work to faith as a supplementary requirement. It insists that biblical faith, rightly understood, was never merely an internal state to begin with. Obedience is not fruit that grows later from a separate root called faith. Obedience is what faith looks like when it is real, in the same way sacrifice is what worship looks like when it is real.

This is the same structural claim made above about mediocrity. If obedience and faith are treated as separable, a person can defer the costly part indefinitely while still affirming the sincere part — precisely the failure mode Malachi, Samuel, and James each diagnose independently.

7. Summary

- The Good has a purpose because it is not an abstraction but the character of God, and God's purpose is union with the people He made.
- Sacrifice exists to make that union verifiable, converting an invisible disposition into a costly, external event that proves the disposition is real.
- Each element of the structure names a real biblical mechanism: the necessity of separation (**Genesis 22**; **Romans 12:1**), the substitution of partial sacrifice for full obedience (**Malachi 1**; **1 Samuel 15**), the demand for total rather than partial commitment (**Luke 14:26–33**), the internal war against holding back (**Romans 6:16**), the false assurance that some goods are exempt from surrender, and the resulting mediocrity James calls futile religion (**James 1:26**).
- Religion, worship, sacrifice, and the obedience of faith are not four separate things but four depths of one act — form, disposition, cost, and settled pattern. Scripture treats none of the first three as reliable evidence on its own. Only the fourth, sustained obedience flowing from faith, is what the New Testament calls acceptable worship (**Romans 12:1**).
- The pattern is possible only because Christ completed it first (**Hebrews 10:5–10**), which is why the living sacrifice Paul calls for is offered *"by the mercies of God"*, a response to a finished work, not an independent bid to earn one.